

SUSTAINABLE TOURISM STRATEGIES IN THE INDIGENOUS COMMUNITY OF URANDEN, MICHOACAN

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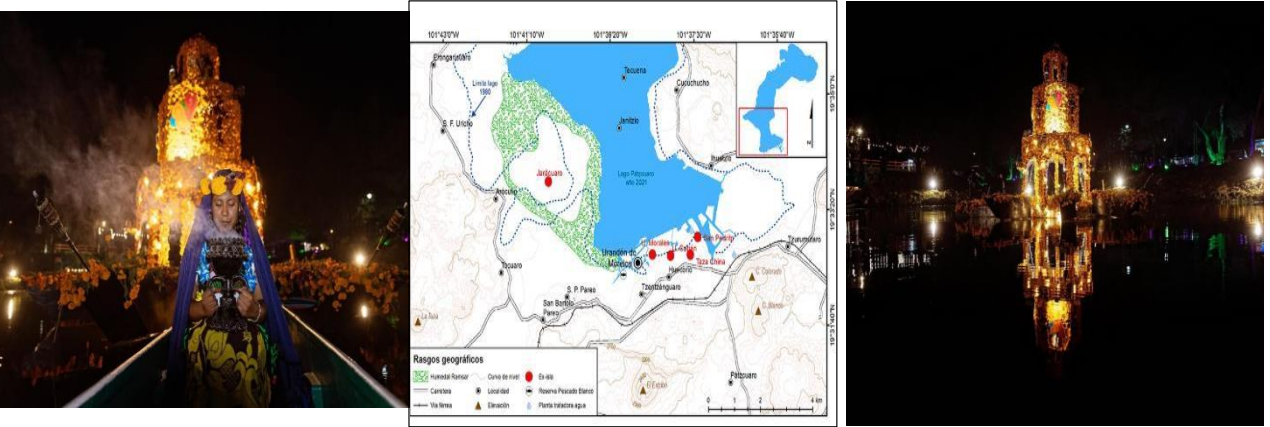
Introduction

The Purépecha indigenous community of Uranden is located on the shores of Lake Pátzcuaro, Michoacán, across a group of islands with crystal-clear springs and a traditional fishing practice using butterfly nets. This natural and cultural environment forms the foundation of a tourism model that, to be truly sustainable, must balance environmental conservation, economic benefits, and the preservation of Purépecha customs. Among these traditions, the Noche de Ánimas (Night of Souls), celebrated on November 2, attracts numerous visitors and reflects the region's deep spiritual identity.

The spring ecosystem depends on rainfall and surface and groundwater runoff (Chacón, 1993). Therefore, increasing tourist pressure represents both an economic opportunity and a challenge for its preservation. Various studies indicate that community management is crucial for developing tourism that benefits local populations while safeguarding their territory (Guzmán et al., 2012). Following this perspective, the present study seeks to identify and propose sustainable tourism strategies based on community management that enable balanced economic development. It also analyzes the potential economic, social, and environmental impacts of tourism while promoting the active participation of residents. As Palomino and López (2008) emphasize, community tourism not only mitigates negative impacts but also strengthens cultural identity and social participation, empowering communities to manage their own resources and determine their future.

From the Purépecha worldview, traditions such as the Noche de Ánimas are central to a tourism model that respects both culture and the natural environment. Drawing on experiences like Ecoturixtlán in Oaxaca, where a community cooperative manages tourism through participatory processes, this project views ecotourism as a way to strengthen Uranden's autonomy and ensure the preservation of its springs and traditions.

- Specific objectives:**
- To evaluate current economic activity and the tourism potential of the Uranden springs.
 - Co-create ecotourism strategies based on participatory and sustainable management.
 - Strengthen environmental awareness and Purépecha cultural identity in tourism practices and management.



Contextualization of the Problem

Since August 2024, the Uranden community has opened its springs to the public to generate tourism income. This decision offers an important economic opportunity but also presents the challenge of conserving a fragile ecosystem and maintaining community control over local resources. The experience of Janitzio Island, also in Michoacán, illustrates the risks of uncontrolled tourism growth: the rapid increase in visitors led to environmental degradation and a damaged reputation that reduced its appeal. Preventing Uranden from repeating this pattern is a central motivation of this study.

That same year, the community organized the first nightly Purépecha canoe show during the *Week of the Dead*, attracting more than 7,000 visitors and generating an estimated economic impact of nearly one million pesos (≈55,000 USD) (Government of Michoacán, 2024). This event demonstrated the potential of cultural and community-based tourism but also revealed the community's dependence on a single tourist season. Diversifying tourism activities throughout the year is therefore essential to ensure a stable and sustainable income.

With this in mind, the present study analyzes sustainable tourism strategies grounded in interactive community participation (Geilfus, 2008). Using a landscape and territorial approach, it seeks to understand the interrelations between natural and socioeconomic elements, and how the community inhabits, manages, and preserves its environment. This analysis aims to identify concrete actions that protect natural resources and reinforce cultural traditions, ensuring tourism development that is respectful, participatory, and sustainable over the long term.



References

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Methodology

The research will be conducted using quantitative and qualitative tools in three stages:

- **Surveys.** Using random probability sampling, a survey will be conducted with 10% of Uranden families to obtain information on the community's perception of tourism and economic impacts.
- **Semi-structured interviews.** Interviews will be conducted with key local economic stakeholders (fishermen, service providers, merchants, and authorities) to identify the benefits, challenges, and opportunities derived from tourism.
- **Participatory workshops.** Workshops will be organized with the key stakeholders identified during the interviews to co-design strategies for environmental preservation and strengthening Purépecha identity in tourism activities.



Expected Results

- **Establish strategies that promote sustainable ecotourism** for the benefit of both the community and the environment.
- **Identify diverse sources of private financing and income** to reduce dependence on the state government.
- **Integrate Purépecha wisdom** as the foundation for practical and ethical ecotourism in the new springs, fostering a harmonious and socially responsible environment that protects the area's flora and fauna.
- **Create a community association** — “Todos por Uranden” — to coordinate collective actions and ensure benefits are distributed equitably.
- **Co-create local regulations** that enable community management of this protected area and guarantee the preservation of its natural resources.
- **Improve residents' quality of life** in social, environmental, political, and economic terms through participatory strategies developed in community workshops



Technological Reflections

The integration of technology in Uranden's ecotourism model aims to complement local wisdom and promote sustainable management of the territory. Possible applications include:

- **Environmental monitoring:** Use of artificial intelligence to analyze satellite or drone images and detect changes in water quality or vegetation cover, generating early warnings of contamination or overuse.
- **Digital experiences for visitors:** Virtual tours and interactive materials to inform visitors about the springs and Purépecha traditions before arrival, as well as video-mapping projections during the *Noche de Ánimas* to promote culturally respectful tourism.
- **Online knowledge exchange:** Virtual workshops with other Indigenous communities to share best practices and strengthen local capacities.
- **Community resource management:** Digital platforms for transparent planning of water use and tourism income, reducing dependence on external actors.

These technologies do not replace community participation; rather, they enhance it by creating new channels for collaboration and environmental stewardship within the technological age.

